





CRIME AND PUNISHMENT
1. Asad Ahmed and Ghulam killed in an encounter in Jhansi, Apr. 13 **2.** A CCTV grab of the Prayagraj murder case (Feb. 24) in which the two were allegedly involved **3.** Victim Umesh Pal

THE AGE OF ENCOUNTERS

In the six years since Yogi Adityanath took over as the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh in March 2017, the state police have killed 183 criminals in encounters, or what police call "proceedings in self defence". Of those killed, 59, or 32 per cent, were Muslims, contrary to the impression that members of this community in particular are targeted.

According to Prashant Kumar, ADG, law & order, in UP, encounters generally happen during a clash between criminals and police. "Some criminals surrender easily, but many start firing or attacking. Police also cross-fire in their defence," he says. "Those who raise questions on encounters should first see the background of these criminals and the kind of weapons they keep."

But this doesn't answer questions being raised over the 'encounter' of Atiq Ahmed's son Asad and his aide Ghulam, who were wanted in the Umesh Pal murder case. The duo was gunned down in Jhansi on April 13. The STF claims their bike overturned and fell off the road during the chase. But there was not a single scratch on the bike, despite the surface being rocky and uneven. Also, no helmet was recovered from the spot. If not for safety, wouldn't they have used helmets to avoid being detected? And how did they manage to enter Jhansi after travelling across states, as the police claim?

183
CRIMINALS KILLED SO FAR IN ENCOUNTERS IN YOGI RULE

Asked about the allegations of encounters being fake, Kumar categorically denies it. He cites inquiries, such as in the 2020 encounter of gangster Vikas Dubey, where the UP police got a clean chit. "Despite inquiries, not a single encounter has been proven fake till now," he asserts.

Samajwadi Party chief and former chief minister Akhilesh Yadav claims that Yogi Adityanath's alleged orders to 'encounter' criminals has sowed confusion in the police force. "The CM keeps saying '*thok do*' (shoot them), whether he is in the assembly or on stage. Sometimes the police don't know whom to '*thok*' and sometimes the people don't know whom to 'thok'," he says.

"Encounter justice is not a solution," says Syed Farman Ahmad Naqvi, a senior lawyer in the Allahabad High Court. "Justice can happen through a legal process, not through the gun." ■